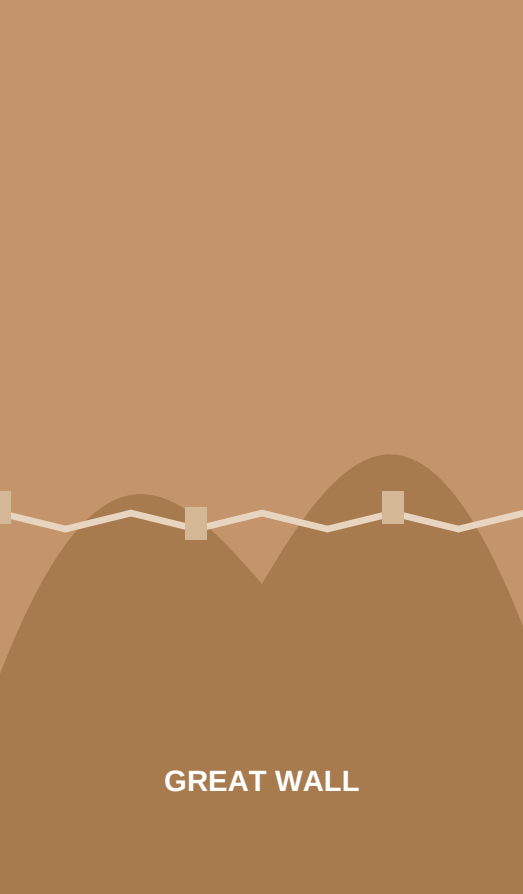
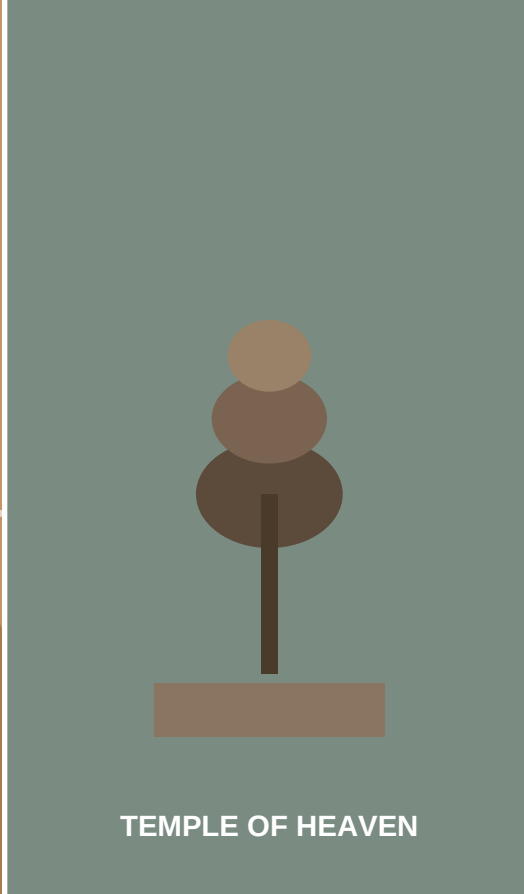
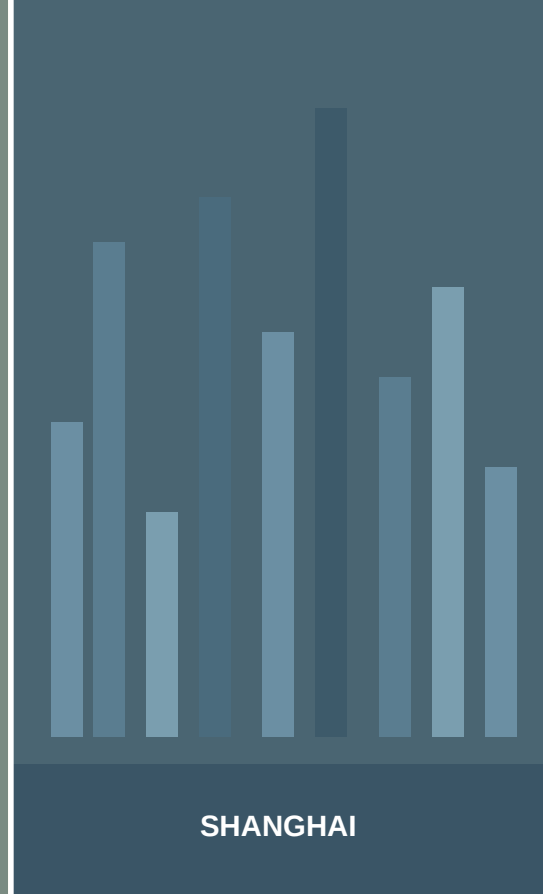




GREAT WALL



TEMPLE OF HEAVEN



SHANGHAI



XI'AN WARRIORS



CHENGDU PANDAS



ANCIENT CHINA

China Bound Travel Guide

2026.05 | Monthly Updates

Joran Chyn

2026.05 Edition

Published monthly on the 1st of every month.

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- APPENDIX A Useful Phone Numbers
- APPENDIX B Visa-Free Policy Quick Reference
- APPENDIX C Packing List

MONTHLY UPDATE SCHEDULE

This guide is updated on the 1st of every month with new city guides, visa changes, and travel tips.

MONTH	NEW CONTENT
June 2026	Guilin and Yangshuo Guide
July 2026	Zhangjiajie Guide
August 2026	Yunnan Guide (Dali, Lijiang, Shangri-La)
September 2026	Street Food Deep Dive
October 2026	Great Wall Complete Guide
November 2026	Ancient Towns of Jiangnan
December 2026	Southern China Winter Guide

INTRODUCTION

Why Visit China in 2026 and How to Use This Guide

Why Visit China in 2026?

I have been traveling to China for over a decade. Married a Chengdu girl. Learned to haggle at Jinli Street before most tourists knew it existed. And I can tell you: 2026 is one of the best times to visit. The infrastructure is incredible, the food is unmatched, and the country is genuinely open to international visitors.

- 240-hour visa-free transit covers major international airports nationwide
- China's high-speed rail network is the world's largest - fast, clean, affordable
- Mobile payments (Alipay / WeChat Pay) now accept foreign cards
- English signage has improved dramatically at airports and major stations
- More flight routes and better connectivity than any previous year

How to Use This Guide

This book is organized in the order you actually need information.

- Before Travel: Chapters 1-3 cover visas, seasons, and budgeting
- Digital Life: Chapters 4-6 cover SIM cards, payments, and must-have apps
- Arrival: Chapters 7-9 cover airports, transport, and hotel check-in
- Getting Around: Chapters 10-12 cover HSR, metro, and ride-hailing
- City Guides: Chapters 13-16 cover Beijing, Shanghai, Xi an, and Chengdu
- Experience: Chapters 17-19 cover customs, food, and shopping
- Safety: Chapters 20-22 cover health, emergency contacts, and precautions
- Itinerary: Chapter 23 gives you a ready-to-use 10-day classic route

Monthly Update System

China travel information changes fast. This guide is republished each month.

- June 2026: Guilin and Yangshuo Guide | July 2026: Zhangjiajie Guide
- Aug 2026: Yunnan Guide | Sep 2026: Street Food Deep Dive
- Oct 2026: Great Wall Guide | Nov 2026: Ancient Towns of Jiangnan
- Dec 2026: Southern China Guide | Jan 2027: Nature Photography
- Feb 2027: Spring Festival Guide | Mar 2027: Family Travel
- Apr 2027: New Transport Updates | May 2027: Premium Travel

Always verify critical info with official Chinese government sources before booking.

About the Author

I'm Joran - American, based in Chengdu, married into a Sichuan family since 2017. I've visited 23 of China's 34 provinces. This guide is everything I wish I had when I first came here.

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Social: @ChinaBoundTravel on X and Pinterest

CHAPTER 1

Visa, Passport and Official Entry Rules

The 240-Hour Visa-Free Transit Policy

This is the most powerful tool for short-stay travelers in 2026.

Eligible nationalities: 54 countries including USA, Canada, UK, Australia, NZ, France, Germany

Maximum stay: 240 hours (10 days)

Entry ports: Major international airports and select land/hydro crossings

Allowed area: Stay within the province or city of entry

Exit rule: Depart via the same port of entry in most cases

No work permitted under visa-free transit

No extensions: Overstaying results in fines and future entry restrictions

The 240-hour clock starts at midnight of the day you clear immigration, not arrival.

144-Hour Visa-Free (Alternative)

Runs alongside the 240-hour option. For Beijing or Shanghai arrivals, check both.

Tourist Visa (L Visa)

Valid 90 days from issue; allows 30-day stay (extendable to 60 days)

Apply at Chinese embassy or consulate in your country of residence

Required: Application form, passport (6+ months validity), photo, outbound ticket, hotel confirmation

Processing: 4-10 business days; cost USD 30-140 by nationality

Multiple-entry L visa available for frequent travelers

Passport Requirements

Minimum 6 months validity beyond your planned China departure

At least one blank page for the entry stamp

Original passport required at immigration

Arrival Immigration Procedure

Complete arrival card, submit fingerprints, present passport. Officers may ask: Where are you staying? How long? Answer confidently. Keep your entry stamp.

Hong Kong SAR and Macau SAR

Separate immigration systems from mainland China. Plan each region independently.

CHAPTER 2

Best Travel Seasons and Chinese Festivals

Best Time to Visit - Overview

China is huge. The best time depends entirely on where you are going.

Best for most of China: Autumn (September to November)

Spring (March to May): Good for south and central regions

Summer (June to August): Crowds, heat, typhoons on coast

Winter (December to February): Cheapest flights, cold north, mild south

Seasonal Guide by Region

Beijing / North China: Sep-Nov cool and clear, Mar-May warm with flowers

Shanghai / East China: Mar-May and Sep-Nov (pleasant temperatures)

Chengdu / Southwest: Mar-May and Sep-Nov (less fog, comfortable)

Guangzhou / South China: Oct-Dec dry; avoid Jun-Sep (typhoons)

Xinjiang / Northwest: May-Oct warm; Winter cold, some roads closed

Yunnan: Oct-Mar dry season; avoid monsoon Jul-Aug

Major Festivals - Plan Ahead

Chinese New Year (Jan/Feb): Country shuts down 7 days. Book 1 month ahead. Hotels 2-3x.

Qingming Festival (Apr 4-6): Tomb-sweeping holiday. Spring travel peak.

Labor Day (May 1-3): Travel peak, especially for domestic tourists.

Dragon Boat Festival (June): 3-day holiday. Zongzi dumplings.

Mid-Autumn Festival (Sep/Oct): Mooncake season. Family gatherings. Travel peak.

National Day Golden Week (Oct 1-7): BIGGEST holiday. Everything books out months ahead.

Avoid Oct 1-7 if you can. Attractions are 5x more crowded and transport is extremely difficult to book.

What to Pack by Season

Summer: Light breathable clothing, rain jacket, sunscreen, hat

Winter: Warm layers, down jacket, thermal underwear, gloves, hat

Shoulder season: Layers - temperatures vary greatly between morning and afternoon

Universal: Comfortable walking shoes. You will walk a lot.

CHAPTER 3

Budget and Money-Saving Tips

Budget Guide (Per Person Per Day in CNY)

Budget: 200-400 CNY (USD 28-56): Hostel dorms, street food, public transport, free attractions

Mid-range: 400-800 CNY (USD 56-112): Private hotel room, sit-down restaurants, some paid attractions

Comfortable: 800-1500 CNY (USD 112-210): International hotel, fine dining, private tours

Luxury: 1500+ CNY (USD 210+): 5-star hotels, premium dining, premium experiences

Biggest Money Traps to Avoid

Airport taxi touts: Always use Didi. Fixed price, no haggling, receipt sent to your phone.

Teahouse scams: Someone invites you to a free tea ceremony - you get a 500+ CNY bill. Walk away.

Fake monk donations: Real monks do not solicit money on the street.

Tourist restaurant with no prices on menu: Walk out.

Hotels booked through Western sites: Book directly or via Trip.com for 20-40% better rates.

Money-Saving Strategies

Book trains 15 days in advance - popular routes sell out fast

Book hotels on Trip.com - 20-40% cheaper than Western sites

Eat where locals eat - street food is 5x cheaper than tourist-area restaurants

Use Didi instead of taxis - fixed price, no haggling, receipt to your phone

Buy eSIM before arrival - much cheaper than roaming packages

CHAPTER 4

Mobile Network: SIM, eSIM, and Wi-Fi

eSIM - Best Option

Activate before you leave home

Works immediately upon landing

Options: Airalo, eSIM.net, Nomad

Typical cost: USD 10-30 for 15-30 days

Must have: Unlocked phone

Chinese SIM Cards (Airport Pickup)

China Mobile, China Telecom, China Unicom at airports

Typical cost: 100-200 CNY for 15-30 days

Requires: Passport for registration

Data speeds: 4G/LTE in cities; 3G in remote areas

VPN - Essential

Set up BEFORE arrival - VPN websites are blocked in China

Astrill VPN: Most consistently reliable in China as of 2026

ExpressVPN / NordVPN: Work with proper configuration

WireGuard protocol: More reliable at some locations

Free VPNs: Not worth it - blocked, slow

CHAPTER 5

Payments: Alipay, WeChat Pay, and Cash

Key Intel

China is nearly cashless. You NEED Alipay or WeChat Pay linked to a foreign card, or cash in CNY.

Setting Up Alipay

- Download Alipay app before departure
- Select Set up for overseas users
- Link a Visa, Mastercard, or Amex card
- Once verified, accepted at 95%+ of merchants

Cash in China

- Needed at: rural markets, small temples, some restaurants
- ATMs accept international cards (10-20 CNY fee per withdrawal)
- Exchange at airport banks - best rates at Bank of China

Credit Cards

- Visa/MC accepted at: international hotels, large restaurants, malls
- NOT accepted at: small restaurants, street vendors, local transport

CHAPTER 6

Useful Travel Apps for China

Essential Apps

Alipay: Payments

WeChat / WeChat Pay: Messaging, payments

Trip.com: Flights, trains, hotels, attractions

Didi: Ride-hailing

Baidu Maps / Gaode Maps: Navigation

Pleco: Chinese-English dictionary

Google Translate: Offline language pack

Communication

WeChat: How you communicate in China

WhatsApp: Blocked in China

Gmail/Outlook: Blocked (use VPN)

CHAPTER 7

Airport Guidance

Major Airports

- Beijing Capital (PEK): Allow 40+ min to city
- Shanghai Pudong (PVG): 45 min to city via maglev/metro
- Shanghai Hongqiao (SHA): Closer to city center
- Chengdu Tianfu (TFU): 50+ min to city
- Guangzhou Baiyun (CAN): 30-40 min to city

Arrival Procedure

- Fill out arrival card
- Immigration - submit fingerprints
- Collect luggage
- Customs - red/green channel

Duty Free Allowance

- Tobacco: 400 cigarettes or 100 cigars (adults)
- Alcohol: 2 bottles (adults)
- Cash: Declare above CNY 20,000
- Goods: Up to 5,000 CNY duty-free

CHAPTER 8

Transportation from Airport to City

Metro / Airport Express

Beijing PEK: Airport Express to Dongzhimen (25 CNY, 20 min)

Shanghai PVG: Maglev (50 CNY, 8 min) + metro OR Metro L2 (7 CNY, 70 min)

Shanghai SHA: Metro L2 to city (7 CNY, 45 min)

Chengdu TFU: Metro L18 (12 CNY, 40 min)

Guangzhou CAN: Metro L3 (8 CNY, 40 min)

Didi - Recommended

Use designated Didi pick-up zones

Price: 80-200 CNY to city center

Must link to Alipay or WeChat Pay

Have hotel address in Chinese characters ready

Taxi

Use only official taxi stands

Usually 1.5x-2x Didi price

Have destination in Chinese characters ready

CHAPTER 9

Hotel Check-in and Rules

Not All Hotels Accept Foreigners

Some Chinese hotels do not have the license to host foreign guests. Always verify before booking.

International chains: Always accept foreigners

Trip.com: Filter by Accepts Foreign Guests

Hostels: Many licensed - check reviews

Check-in Requirements

Passport required - hotel copies your information

Registration with local police within 24 hours - normal

Credit card for incidentals even if paying cash

CHAPTER 10

High-Speed Rail Guide

Key Intel

China has the worlds most advanced high-speed rail network. For trips under 1000 km, the train is almost always faster, cheaper, and more comfortable than flying.

The HSR Network

Network: 42,000+ km of HSR lines

Speed: 250-350 km/h

Coverage: All major cities and many regional centers

Beijing-Shanghai: 4.5 hours by train vs 2 hours by air (but door-to-door time is similar)

Booking Trains

Trip.com app: Best English interface for booking

China Railway app (12306): Official, sometimes shows more availability

Tickets released 15 days in advance - book early for popular routes

Classes: Second class, First class, Business class

Beijing-Shanghai: ~550 CNY second class, ~950 CNY first class

Practical Tips

Bring your passport - ticket is tied to your ID number

Large bags go in dedicated storage areas, not overhead bins

Arrive 30 min before departure - stations are large

Second class is fine for 3-4 hour journeys; first class worth it for 5+ hours

CHAPTER 11

City Public Transport

Metro and Subway

Beijing: 27+ lines - fastest way around

Shanghai: 18 lines - extensive coverage

Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Chengdu, Hangzhou all have large metro systems

Payment: Alipay/WeChat Pay metro function, or single-journey tickets at machines

Avoid rush hour: 8-9 AM and 6-7 PM in major cities - brutally crowded

Bus

Extensive coverage in all cities

Cash or transit card only at some stops

English signage limited on buses

Use for routes not covered by metro - cheaper but slower

Cycling

Didi Bike / Meituan Bike: Dockless bike sharing - scan to unlock with WeChat/Alipay

Cost: 1-3 CNY per ride

Rules: Ride in bike lanes where available; obey traffic signals

Great for short trips in flat cities like Shanghai and Hangzhou

CHAPTER 12

Taxis and Ride-Hailing

Didi - China Uber

Download and set up Didi before arrival - requires Chinese phone number or foreign number registered in advance

Didi Express: Economy option

Didi Premier: Higher-end vehicles

Price: Fixed price shown before you confirm

Payment: Alipay or WeChat Pay only - cash not accepted by most drivers

Regular Taxi

Available on streets and at taxi stands

Metered fares - generally reliable

May not speak English - have destination in Chinese ready

Use Didi instead - more transparent pricing

Long-Distance Ride-Hailing

Didi works for intercity trips within ~300 km

For longer distances, high-speed rail is usually faster and cheaper

CHAPTER 13

Beijing Travel Guide

Key Intel

Beijing is enormous and historic. The Forbidden City takes a full day. The Great Wall needs a separate day trip. Budget 4-6 days.

Best season: Sep-Oct (autumn) and Mar-Apr (spring flowers)

Airport: Beijing Capital (PEK) - allow 40+ min to city center

Metro: 27+ lines; avoid rush hour 8-9 AM and 6-7 PM

The Forbidden City

Tickets: 60 CNY high season, 40 CNY low season

Hours: 8:30 AM-5 PM (last entry 4 PM)

Plan: Minimum 4 hours - 180 acres, 980 buildings

Arrive at opening to avoid crowds; exit via Jingshan Park north gate for iconic view

The Great Wall

Badaling: Closest and most crowded - avoid weekends

Mutianyu: Best balance of accessibility and authenticity - 45 CNY + 15 CNY shuttle

Jinshanling: Most photogenic; wild section for hikers

Allocate full day - transport is slow

Temple of Heaven

UNESCO site; imperial sacrifice altar and temple

Tickets: 15 CNY (park) or 34 CNY (includes hall)

Morning: Locals practice tai chi and calligraphy here

The Hutongs

Ancient narrow alley neighborhoods - free to walk

Shichahai: Beautiful lakes area with historic courtyard homes

Cycling: Rent a bike (20-30 CNY/day) and explore

Summer Palace

Imperial garden with massive lake - 4+ hours to explore

Tickets: 30 CNY (park), 60 CNY (includes hall)

CHAPTER 14

Shanghai Travel Guide

Key Intel

Shanghai is Asia's most Westernized city and the easiest Chinese metropolis for first-time visitors. English is more widespread here than anywhere else in China.

Best season: Mar-May and Sep-Nov

Airports: Pudong (PVG) international, Hongqiao (SHA) domestic

Metro: 18 lines with English signage

The Bund

Free waterfront promenade - always open

Best view: From Pudong side at night when buildings are lit

52 buildings in Gothic/Renaissance style from 1843-1937

Walk: Full Bund walk takes 30-45 min; do at sunset then stay for lights

Yu Garden

Ming dynasty garden in old Shanghai

Tickets: 40 CNY adults

Crowded on weekends - go early morning or late afternoon

Shanghai Tower

128 floors, 632m - 2nd tallest building in the world

Observatory: 180 CNY (118F) via Trip.com

Best time: Sunset - daylight and night views in one visit

French Concession

Tree-lined streets, colonial architecture, trendy cafes

Xintiandi: Shikumen buildings converted to shops

Anfu Road: Cafes and boutiques - prettiest street in Shanghai

CHAPTER 15

Xian Travel Guide

Key Intel

Xian is where East meets West historically. The Terracotta Army is jaw-dropping. The city walls are rideable and the Muslim Quarter is incredible.

Best season: Mar-May and Sep-Nov

Airport: Xian Xianyang (XIY) - 45 min to city center

Metro: 9 lines; airport express available

Terracotta Warriors

Location: 35km east of city - taxi or Bus 5 from station

Tickets: 120 CNY high season, 80 CNY low + 20 CNY shuttle

Plan: 3-4 hours - three pits plus museum

Hire a guide: 200-300 CNY for licensed local guide - worth every yuan

Xian City Walls

Complete circuit: 13.7 km of Ming dynasty walls

Tickets: 54 CNY to walk/cycle; bike rental 45 CNY per person

Cycling: 2 hours for full circuit

Great Mosque and Muslim Quarter

Free entry to mosque; Muslim Quarter is a bustling night market

Street food: Roujiamo (Chinese burger), yang rou pao mo, biang biang mian

Halaal: All food here - look for green sign

CHAPTER 16

Chengdu Travel Guide

Key Intel

Chengdu is China at its most livable. The pace is slower than Beijing or Shanghai. People are relaxed. The food is incredible. Pandas are here. And the tea houses in the park are pure magic. Plan 3-5 days minimum.

Best season: Mar-May (flowers), Sep-Nov (golden ginkgos)

Airport: Chengdu Tianfu (TFU) - newer, larger, English signage throughout

Best area to stay: Near Jinjiang District (central)

Panda Base

Location: 10 km north of city - take Metro L3 to Panda Avenue then taxi

Hours: 7:30 AM-6 PM - arrive at opening for most active pandas

Tickets: 55 CNY adults via Trip.com; buy at entrance

Plan: 3-4 hours minimum - it is large with lots of walking

Red Panda enclosure: Separate from giant pandas - equally adorable

Photography: No flash. Pandas sleep 14+ hours a day

Jinli Street

Free entry pedestrian street - old Sichuan architecture

Best time: Evening after 7 PM when lanterns are lit

What to eat: Longchao shuijiao, tanghulu, dan dan noodles

Tip: Walk past the main entrance and explore the side alleys - less touristy

People Park

Free to enter - authentic local experience

Morning: Tai chi practitioners, ballroom dancers

Afternoon/evening: Ear cleaning (20 CNY), ear reading, matchmaking corners

Mahjong: Tables available for rental - a quintessential Chengdu experience

Tea houses: Sit under banyan trees, order Sichuan green tea (15-30 CNY)

Day Trips

Leshan Giant Buddha: 90 km away - largest Buddha statue in the world. HSR + taxi. Half day.

Mount Emei: Buddhist mountain. HSR to Emeishan then bus. 2 days minimum.

Dujiangyan: Ancient flood control system, UNESCO. HSR from Chengdu. 1-2 hours.

CHAPTER 17

Local Customs and Etiquette

Basic Etiquette

Queue: Always form a line

Speaking loudly on public transport is common

Smoking: Banned in most indoor spaces

Dining Etiquette

Chopsticks: Never stick chopsticks vertically into rice

Food is placed in the center for sharing

Finishing your plate is a compliment to the host

Gift-Giving

Bring small gifts from your country when invited to a home

Avoid: Clocks, white flowers (funeral associations)

CHAPTER 18

Food and Dining Guide

Key Intel

Chinese food is the reason I keep coming back. Get out into the street markets.

Regional Cuisines

Sichuan: Mapo doufu, huiguo rou, dan dan mian, hotpot

Beijing: Peking duck, jianbing, lamb hotpot

Shanghai: Xiaolongbao, braised pork belly, hairy crabs (Sep-Nov)

Cantonese: Dim sum, Siu Mei roast meats, fresh seafood

Xian: Roujiamo, biang biang mian, yang rou pao mo

Hotpot - The National Sport

Hotpot is a social institution. You sit around a simmering broth, add raw ingredients, wait, and fish them out with chopsticks.

Night Markets

Chengdu: Jinli Street, Lu Xun Bar Street

Beijing: Wangfujing Snack Street

Shanghai: Wujiaogang Road

Xian: Huimin Street near Bell Tower

CHAPTER 19

Shopping Advice

Where to Shop

Markets: Best prices, requires bargaining

Department stores: Fixed prices

Shopping malls: Modern, clean

TaoBao / JD.com: Delivery to your hotel

Bargaining

Expected in markets, not in department stores

Start at 30-40% of asking price, meet in the middle

What to Buy

Silk: Hangzhou silk

Tea: Hangzhou Longjing, Yunnan Pu-erh

Porcelain: Jingdezhen

Cashmere: Inner Mongolia

CHAPTER 20

Travel Safety

General Safety

China is extremely safe for travelers. Violent crime is rare.

Common Scams

Taxi scams: Always use Didi

Tea house scam: Free tea invitation = 500+ CNY bill

Fake monk donations: Walk away

Emergency Numbers

Police: 110

Ambulance: 120

Fire: 119

CHAPTER 21

Help Information and Resources

Your Embassy

Register with your embassy upon arrival

Lost passport: Go to police station first, then embassy

Credit cards: Call your bank immediately to freeze

CHAPTER 22

Health Tips

Common Health Issues

Diarrhea: Common when changing food environments. Drink bottled water.

Altitude sickness: In Xizang and high-altitude areas. Ascend slowly.

Air quality: Some cities have occasional poor air quality days.

Medical Care

Major cities: International clinics with English-speaking staff

Travel insurance: Essential

Pharmacies: Many in every city

Water and Food Safety

Tap water: Not safe to drink. Use bottled water.

Street food: Safe if the stall is busy

CHAPTER 23

10-Day Classic China Travel Plan

Overview

This itinerary covers Beijing, Xian, Shanghai, and Chengdu.

Day 1-3: Beijing

Day 1: Arrive Beijing. Evening walk.

Day 2: Forbidden City (full day). Jingshan Park at sunset.

Day 3: Temple of Heaven (morning). Summer Palace (afternoon).

Day 4: Great Wall

Full day at Mutianyu Great Wall.

Day 5-6: Xian

Day 5: HSR to Xian. City Walls cycling.

Day 6: Terracotta Warriors (full day, hire a guide).

Day 7-8: Shanghai

Day 7: HSR to Shanghai. The Bund at sunset.

Day 8: Yu Garden (morning). Shanghai Tower at sunset.

Day 9-10: Chengdu

Day 9: Flight to Chengdu. Panda Base (arrive at opening).

Day 10: People Park (morning). Hotpot lunch. Depart.

Budget Estimate

Accommodation: 150-400 CNY/night mid-range

Transport: ~1,500 CNY total

Attractions: ~600 CNY total

Total: ~8,000-12,000 CNY per person for 10 days

CONCLUSION

Your China Journey Starts Now

The Best Advice I Can Give You

Go in with open eyes and low expectations of comfort. China will challenge you, frustrate you, and occasionally make you furious. And then you will eat something extraordinary, meet someone unexpectedly kind, and see something that stops you in your tracks - and you will come back changed. That is what China does to you. The discomfort is part of it. The food is part of it. The people are part of it. The whole messy, incredible, enormous experience is part of it.

Practical Reminders

Download your apps before you go. Get a VPN working before you land. Link your Alipay before you need it. Book your Panda Base tickets the night before. Bring comfortable shoes. Learn to say Xie xie. And for the love of all that is good - do not try to see everything. Pick a few places. Go deep. That is how you will actually understand China.

Monthly Updates

This guide is updated on the 1st of every month with corrections, new openings, and policy changes. The next update (June 2026) will include a full Guilin and Yangshuo Guide. Thank you for reading.

APPENDICES

APPENDIX A: Useful Phone Numbers

Emergency Numbers

Police: 110 (English support in major cities)

Ambulance: 120

Fire: 119

Traffic accident: 122

Government Hotlines

China travel information: 12301 (tourist hotline, English available)

Consumer complaints: 12315

■■■■ (Weather forecast): 12121

Embassy Emergency Contacts

Carry your embassy contact details saved offline

VPN required to access embassy websites from China

Most embassies have 24-hour emergency lines

APPENDIX B: Visa-Free Policy Quick Reference

240-Hour Visa-Free Transit

Available at: Beijing, Shanghai, Guangzhou, Chengdu, and 50+ other ports

Eligible: Passport holders from 54 countries

Restriction: Must stay within the province/city of entry

Requirement: Must have confirmed onward ticket

144-Hour Visa-Free Transit

Available at: Beijing, Shanghai, Guangzhou, Shenzhen and select other cities

Broader geographical flexibility at some ports compared to 240-hour option

Countries Eligible for Visa-Free Transit

Europe: All EU countries, UK, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland

Americas: USA, Canada, Brazil, Argentina, Chile, Mexico

Asia-Pacific: Australia, New Zealand, Japan, South Korea, Singapore

Middle East: UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Oman

APPENDIX C: Packing List

Documents

Passport (6+ months validity)

Printed hotel confirmations

Printed flight/train tickets

Travel insurance policy (printed or saved offline)

Embassy contact details (saved offline)

Credit cards (notify your bank before travel)

Electronics

- Phone and charger
- Power adapter (China uses Type I, 220V/50Hz)
- Portable battery pack
- VPN already configured before arrival
- Offline maps downloaded (Baidu Maps or Gaode Maps)

Daily Essentials

- Comfortable walking shoes
- Reusable water bottle
- Basic toiletries (hotels provide most things)
- Sunscreen and hat (essential in summer)
- Light jacket (for air-conditioned venues and cool evenings)
- (folding umbrella) - useful year-round

Health

- Personal medications (enough for trip plus extras)
- Basic first aid kit
- Hand sanitizer
- Water purification tablets (for rural areas)

Optional But Useful

- Small gift from your home country (for hospitality situations)
- Chinese phrase book or phrase card
- Photocopies of passport (stored separately)
- Neck pillow for long train rides

CHINA BOUND

TRAVEL GUIDE 2026

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Your Honest Field-Tested Playbook